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Creating the Sacred through Decor: Chapels, Oratories and AI-Based Simulation in Late Medieval Loire Court Spaces

This paper proposes to examine the creation of sacred space at court through the material, visual and sensorial arrangement of chapels and oratories in the Loire region during the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries. Rather than considering sacredness as an inherent quality of a place, it approaches it as the result of staged interactions between architecture, images, objects, light, sound, smell, textiles and embodied devotional practices. The case study derives from two ongoing doctoral projects, one devoted to the representation and materialisation of the decoration of chapels and oratories in late medieval Loire courtly contexts, the other to heritage digital twins and generative AI. Particular attention will be paid to the degree of personalisation introduced by patrons through heraldry, donor imagery, funerary devices, liturgical furnishings, textiles and visual references to dynastic or princely models. The aim is to understand how these elements shaped both private devotion and public representation within courtly sacred environments. The paper will also present a proof-of-concept developed through this interdisciplinary collaboration. Taking as a point of departure the announced development of *By God Alone for Crusader Kings III*, and more broadly the logic of historical simulation and game modding, the prototype allows a medieval lord to arrange a devotional space by selecting architectural, decorative and sensory components. Each generated environment is not presented as a definitive reconstruction, but as a historically constrained hypothesis, associated with degrees of probability depending on the nature of the sources used: surviving remains, textual descriptions, inventories, iconography or analogical comparison. By combining art-historical analysis, AI-assisted generation and critical modelling, this contribution asks how digital methods can help us think through the seriality of sacred decor, the uncertainty of lost interiors, and the performative production of holiness in courtly spaces. It therefore treats simulation not as an illustrative tool, but as an epistemological device for questioning how the sacred was materially and sensorially created at court.